

Life in the air

Some birds are spectacular acrobats. They are the experts of the air – a few can even fly backwards! Many birds spend most of their lives in the air.

Hummingbirds

These tiny birds beat their wings in a figure-of-eight pattern. This means that they can hover and fly backwards! Smaller species beat their wings 80 times a second.

Record holder

The smallest bird in the world is the bee hummingbird. Found in Cuba, it feeds on nectar from flowers. Its eggs are smaller than peas!



Bee hummingbird

Some flying insects are bigger than the bee hummingbird.

Hummingbirds have long beaks that can poke into flowers to sip the nectar.

Magenta-throated woodstar hummingbird

Air acrobats

Swifts, swallows, and martins have forked tails that help them to control their flight. They can catch insects while they are flying and even swoop down over water, like this swallow, and drink without landing.



Swallow